



Dani and Niraj Bajaj, UTT has featured the crème de la crème of Indian table tennis along with several well-known global stars since its inception in 2017.

The tournament has typically been organised in June and July, except for the last season, which began in late August due to the Paris Olympics. However, the upcoming edition, comprising 23 ties across 16 days, begins less than a week after the conclusion of the World Championships in Doha on May 25, where 20 of the 48 UTT players are in action. "It's a very small window that we have. Players don't play every day, and the amount of game time is also very concise," Dani told *Sportstar* when asked about potential concerns regarding fatigue or withdrawals by those participating in Doha.

"We have to strike a balance between the international and the sporting calendar in India. We usually like to start after the IPL (Indian Premier League) because that is when the excitement is maximum. It also helps with our promotions, as viewership is at its peak. Keeping the international calendar in mind, we don't want to clash with major events. It affects participation from both Indian and overseas players."

First-ever auction

After operating under a draft system for the first five seasons, the league held its first-ever auction on

April 15 in Mumbai, where each of the eight teams had a notional purse of Rs. 50 lakh. Harmeet Desai and Sreeja Akula were retained by Dempo Goa Challengers and Jaipur Patriots, respectively, via the Right to Match card. Manika Batra was signed by Ahmedabad SG Pipers after PBG Pune Jaguars released the star paddler.

Fan Siqi, the only Chinese participant, emerged as the most valued player at Rs. 19.70 lakh. However, this value is not the actual amount paid. Each player has been contracted by UTT for an undisclosed fee. "It (the auction) is just to create more excitement. It introduces more variables and provides strategic options, opening up many avenues." Although there will be no top 10 player for the fifth consecutive season, Indian athletes will have the chance to compete with and against several established international stars, such as Romania's Bernadette Szocs (World No. 13), Puerto Rico's Adriana Diaz (World No. 17) and Nigeria's Quadri Aruna (World No. 25).

New additions

Apart from a new host city, this edition has several other additions. A new franchise, Kolkata Thunder Blades — co-owned by Uneecops and Mvikas — replaces Bengaluru Smashers. The Puneri Paltan has also rebranded itself as PBG Pune Jaguars. An Under-15 event titled Dream UTT

Format



- The eight teams have been split equally into two groups.
- Each team will face the other three teams in its group, as well as two sides from the opposite group.
- Inter-group match-ups (example):
If Group A has teams 1, 3, 5, 7 and Group B has teams 2, 4, 6, 8, then:
Team 2 plays Team 1 and Team 3
Team 4 plays Team 1 and Team 3
Team 6 plays Team 5 and Team 7
Team 8 plays Team 5 and Team 7
- Each tie comprises two men's singles, two women's singles, and one mixed doubles match. Every match includes three games.
- Unlike international rules requiring a two-point lead to win a game, UTT uses a Golden Point to decide games tied at 10–10. The team that wins eight games in total wins the tie.
- The top four teams will advance to the knockout stage.

Juniors will run alongside the main tournament.

Targeting organic growth in attendance

Since the league began in 2017, India has won 15 medals at the Commonwealth Games, three at the Asian Games, and seven at the Asian Championships. Indian players such as Manika, Harmeet, Sreeja, Manav Thakkar, Manush Shah, G. Sathiyam, Ayhika Mukherjee, Sutirtha Mukherjee and Diya Chitale have benefitted from competing in UTT against high-quality international opponents.

The presence of such players can only inspire and benefit the next generation of Indian talent.

However, Achanta Sharath Kamal (**above**) — India's most decorated paddler and a key figure in the country's global success in the sport — retired after the WTT Star Contender in March and will not feature as a player in UTT 6. Also, two